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(54) **STADIUM FOOD TRAY AND DRINK CARRIER APPARATUS**

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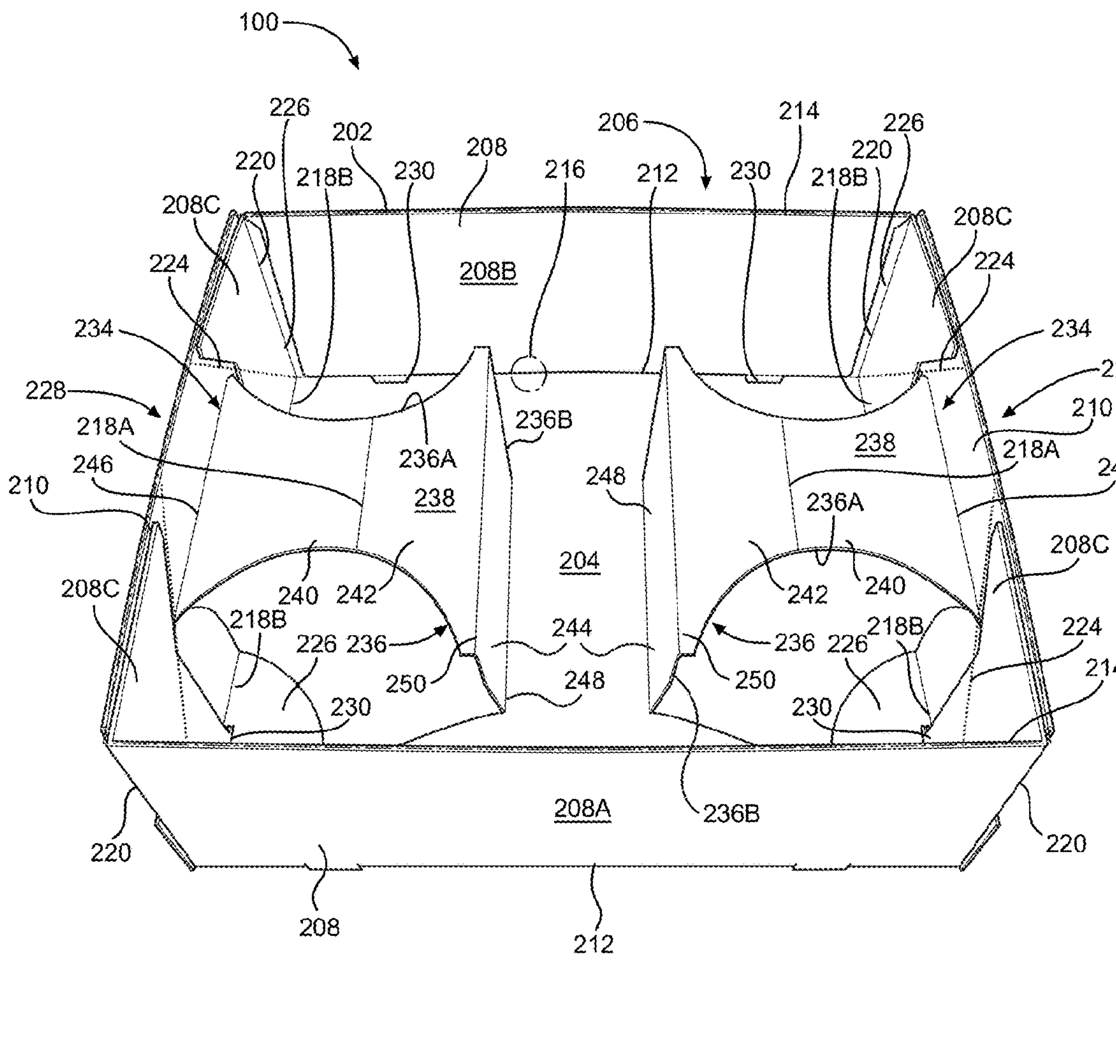
(57) **ABSTRACT**

A food and drink container apparatus and method for forming the same is disclosed. The apparatus includes a carrier having a peripheral wall that defines a food and drinks space and that is movable between a collapsed configuration and at least two expanded configurations. A popout holder is located within and is used to modify the configuration of the food and drinks space by being selectively moved between a food tray configuration providing a flat space suitable for securing and holding food and a drink carrier configuration providing an upright support in place of the flat space suitable for securing and holding a drink container. The apparatus may also be configured to provide a combination drink carrier and food tray.



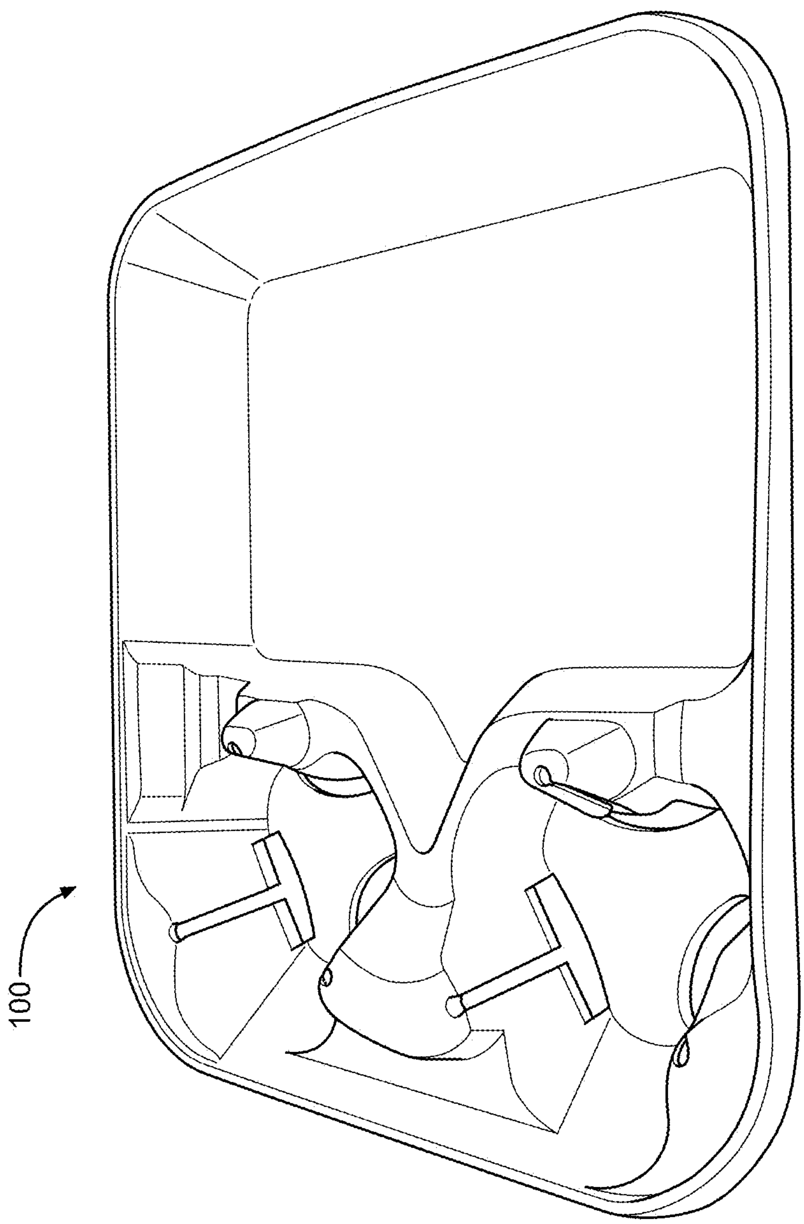
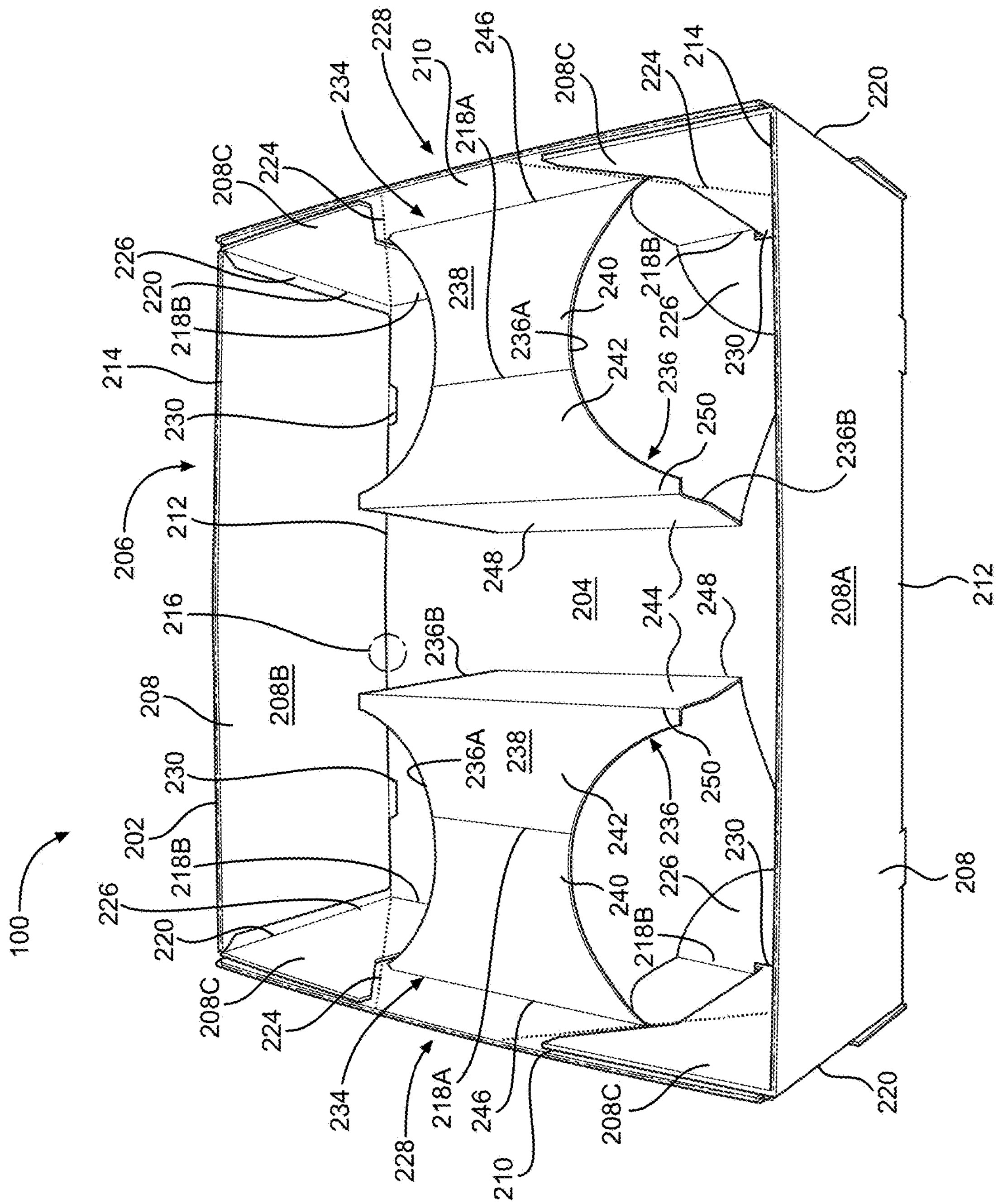


FIG. 1
Prior Art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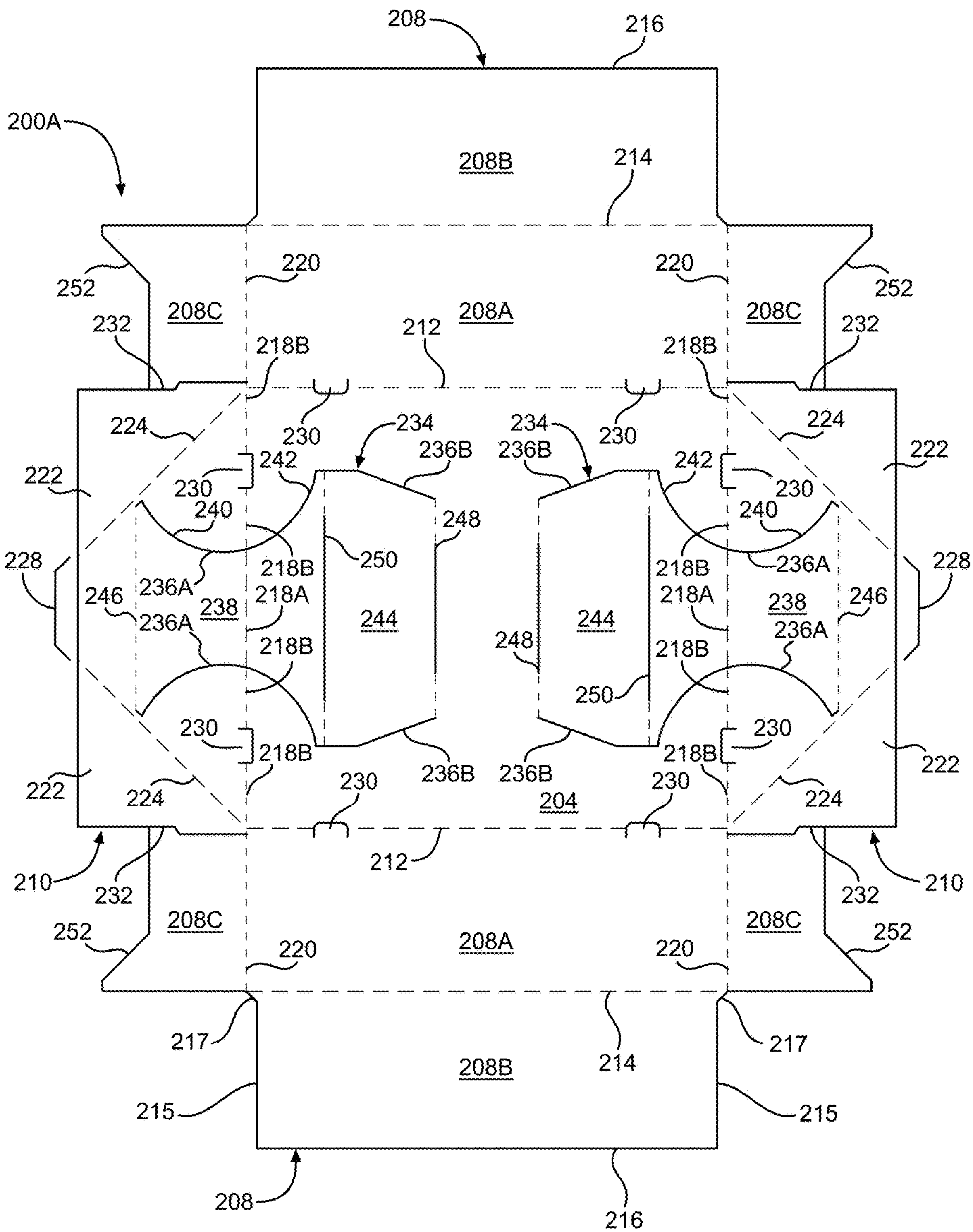
202
204
206
208
208A
208B
208C
210
212
214
216
218A
218B
220
224
226
228
230
234
236
236A
236B
238
240
242
244
246
248
250

FIG. 2


208
216
200A
208B
214
220
220
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208C
208A
208C
252
232
212
232
218B
218B
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234
234
230
224
222
230
236B
236B
222
222
242
242
230
230
240
240
228
248
228
218B
250
218B
236A
246
236A
218A
218A
238
246
238
244
244
236A
236A
218B
248
218B
250
230
230
218B
218B
236B
236B
222
222
224
230
204
230
224
210
212
210
232
232
208C
208A
208C
252
252
220
220
217
217
208B
214
215
215
208
216

FIG. 3

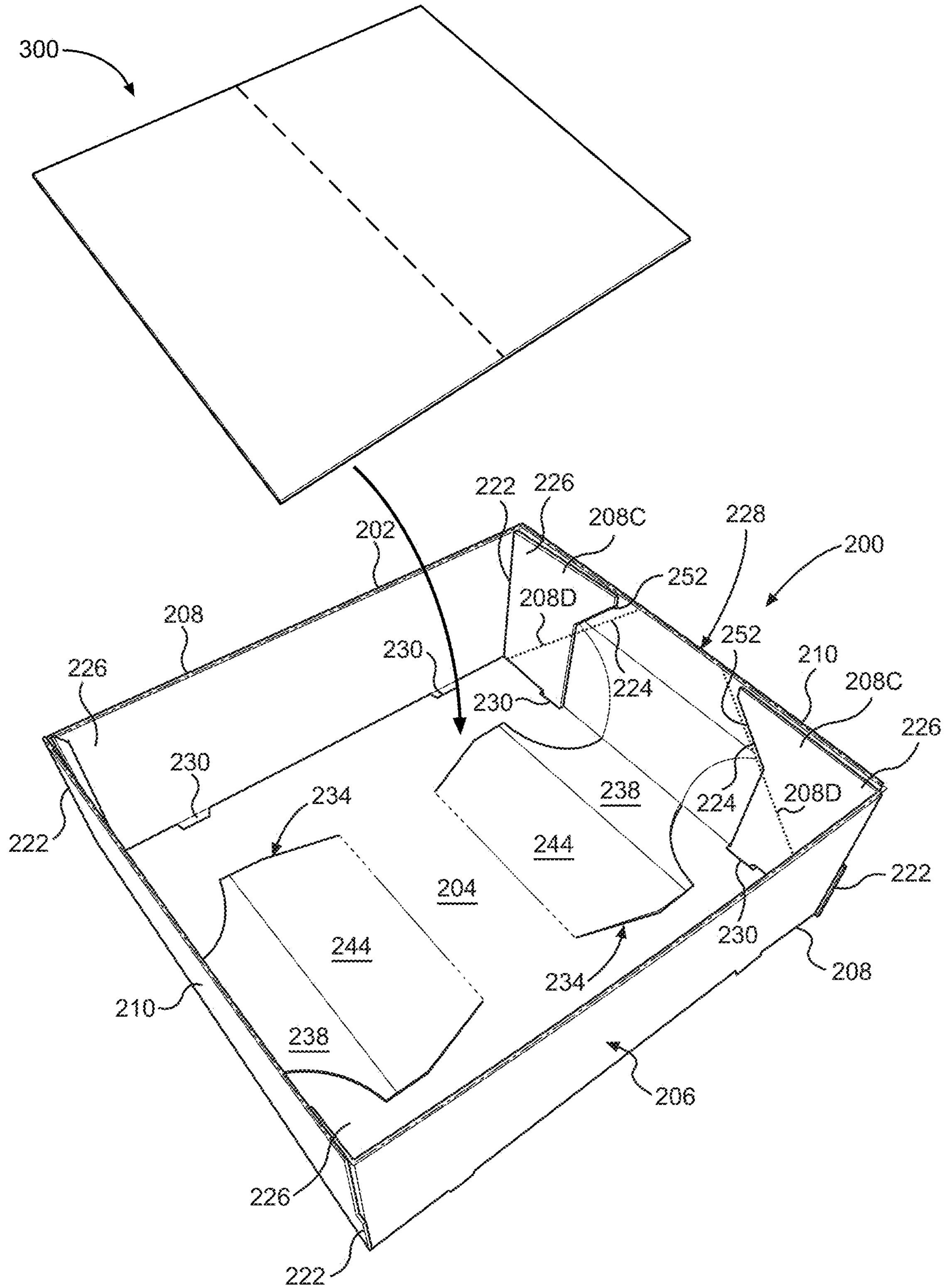

300
222
226
208C
228
200
202
252
208
208D
230
252
210
226
230
224
208C
230
226
234
238
224
208D
244
222
222
204
244
230
210
234
208
238
206
226
222

FIG. 4

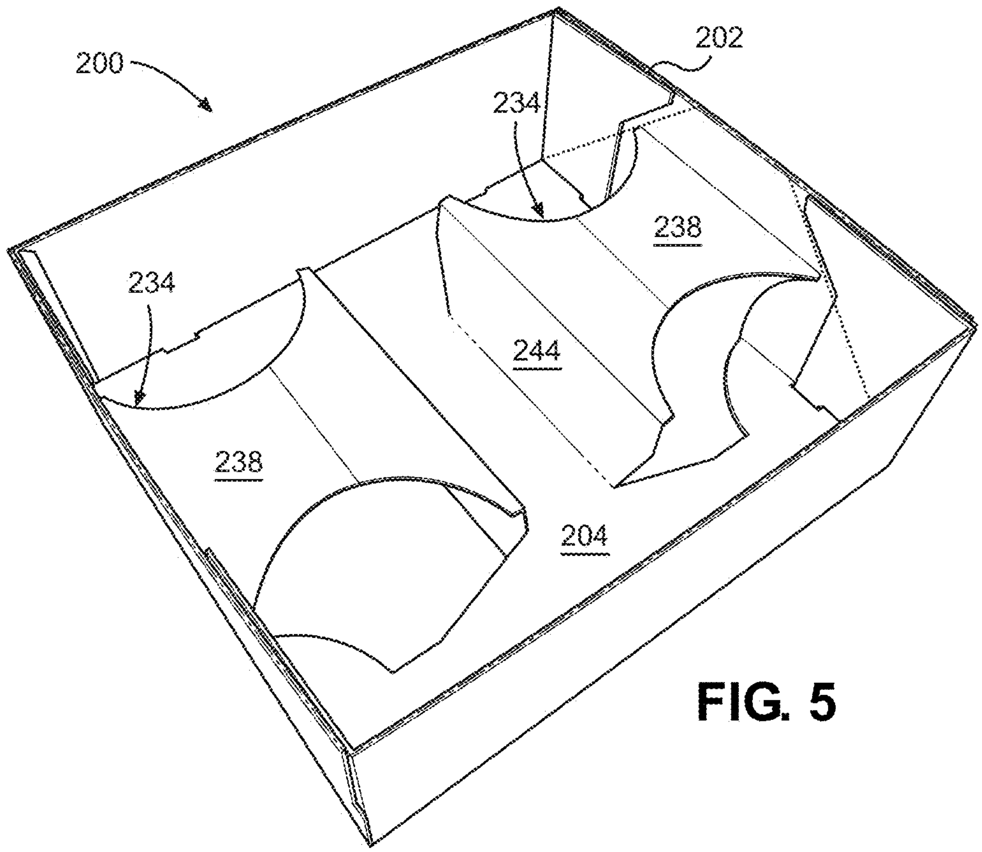


FIG. 5

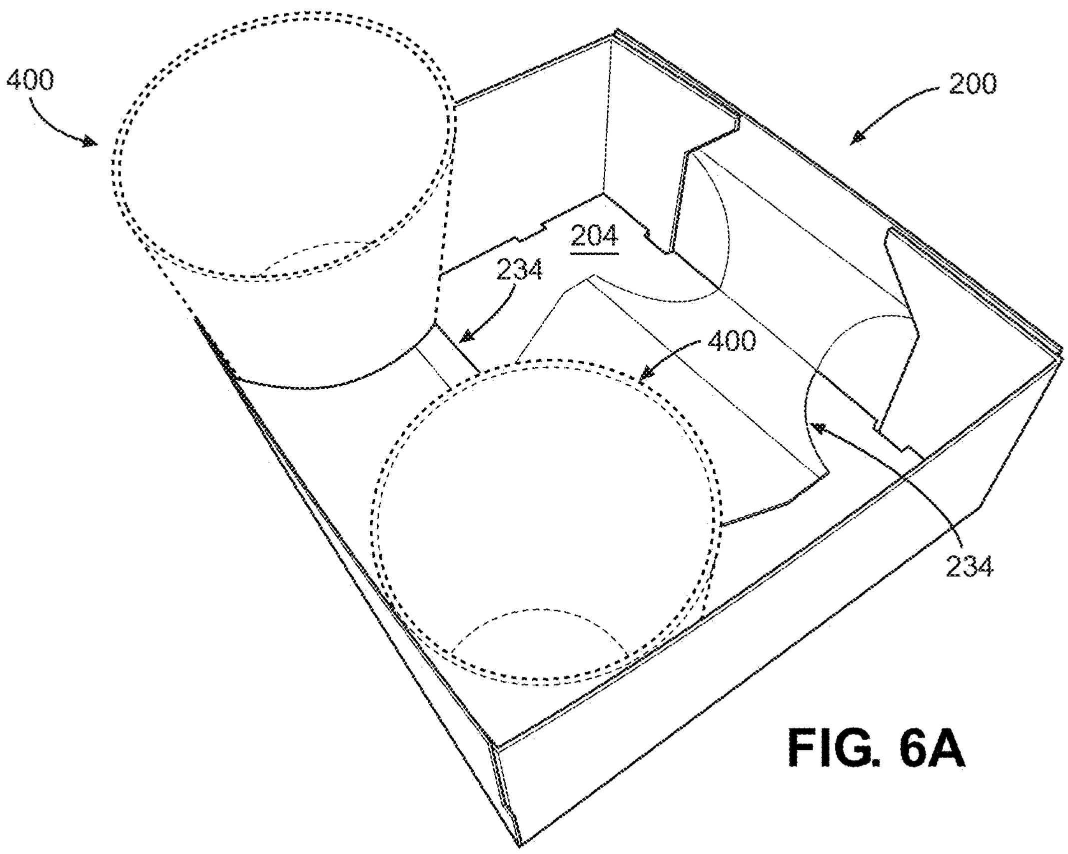


FIG. 6A

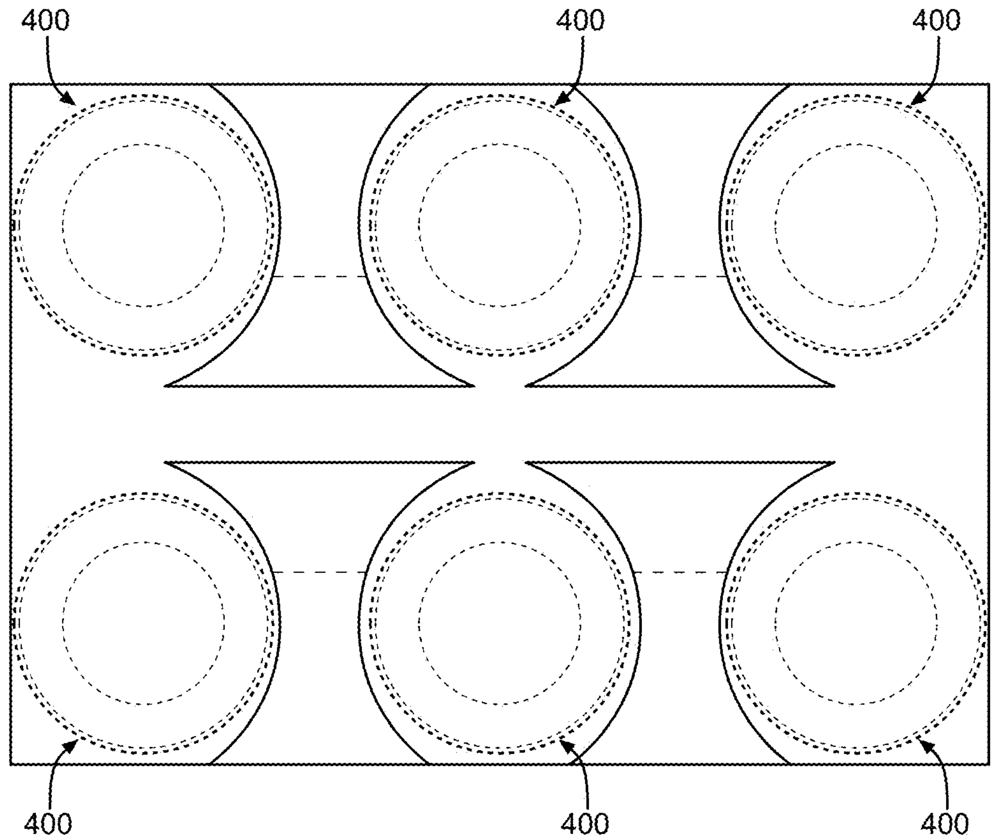

400
400
400
400
400
400

FIG. 6B

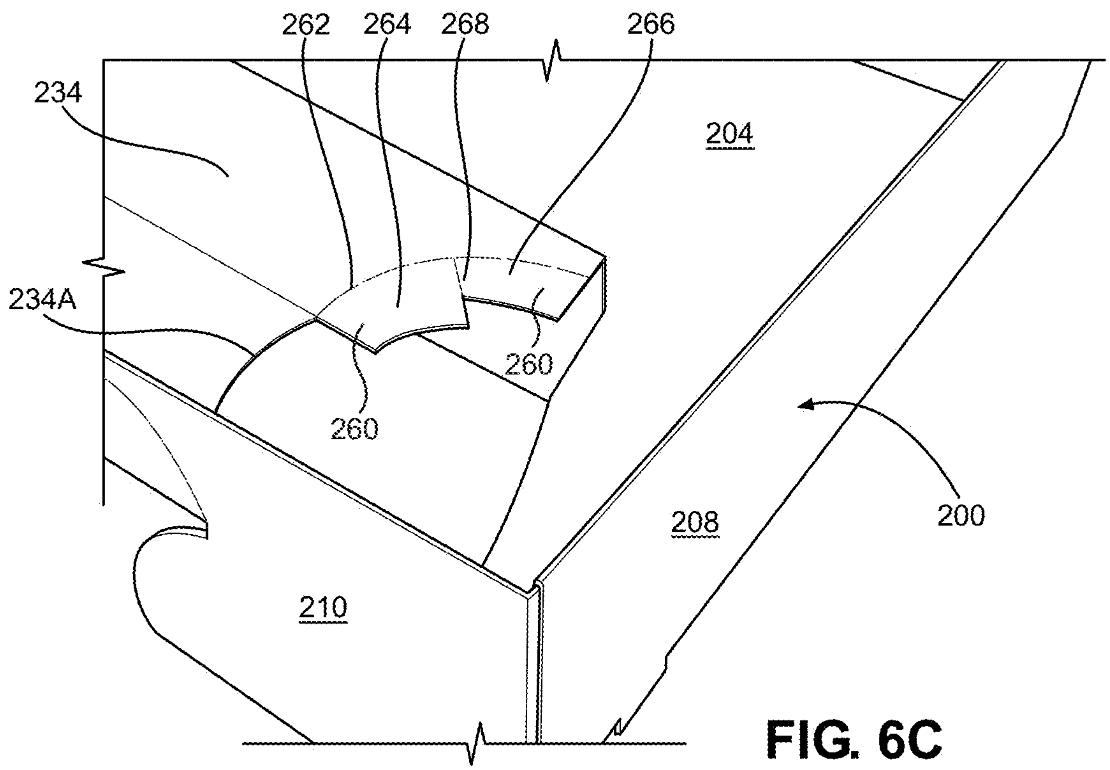

262
264
268
266
234
204
234A
260
260
208
200
210

FIG. 6C

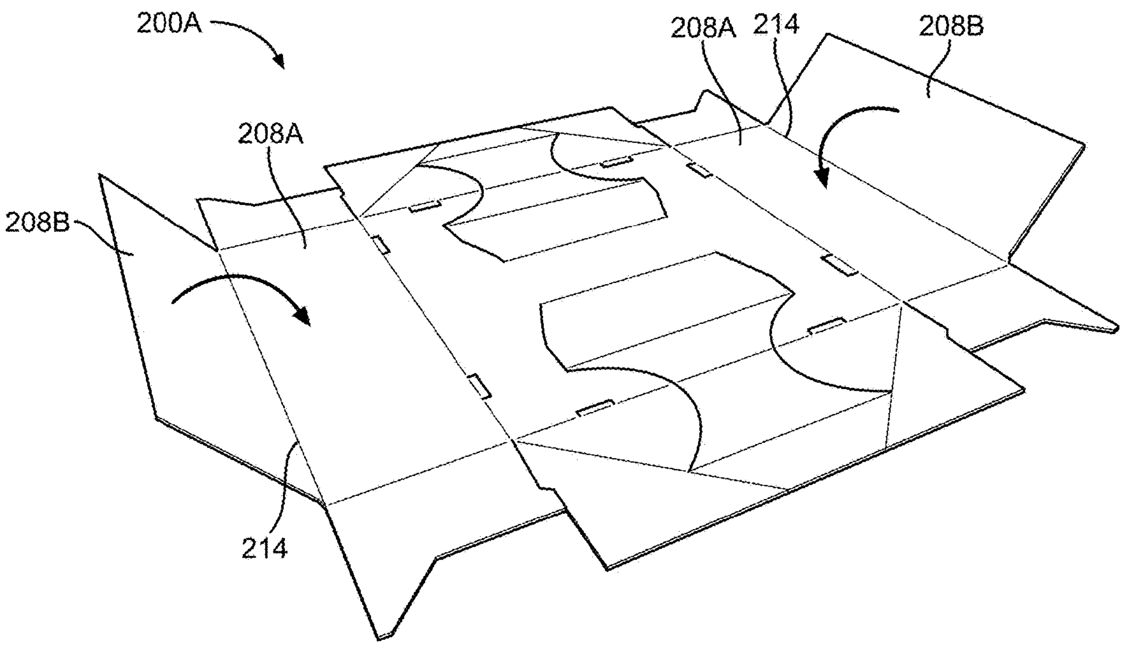

200A
208A
214
208B
208A
208B
214

FIG. 7

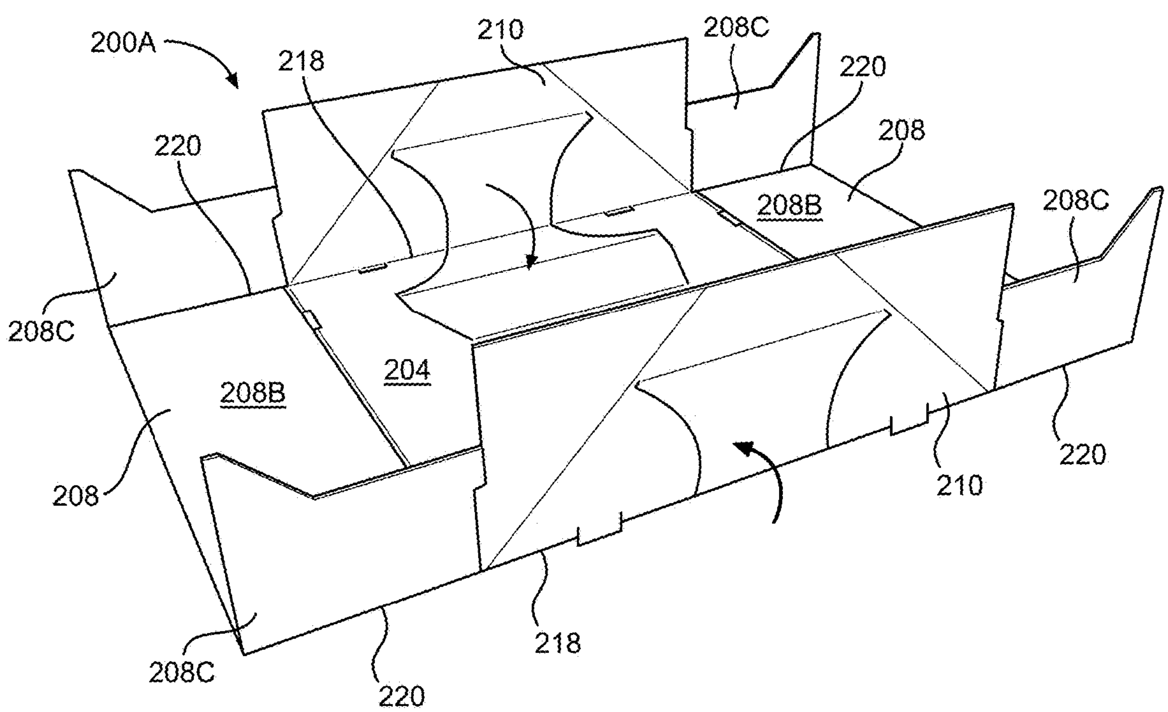

200A
218
210
208C
220
208
220
208B
208C
208C
204
208B
208
220
210
218
208C
220

FIG. 8

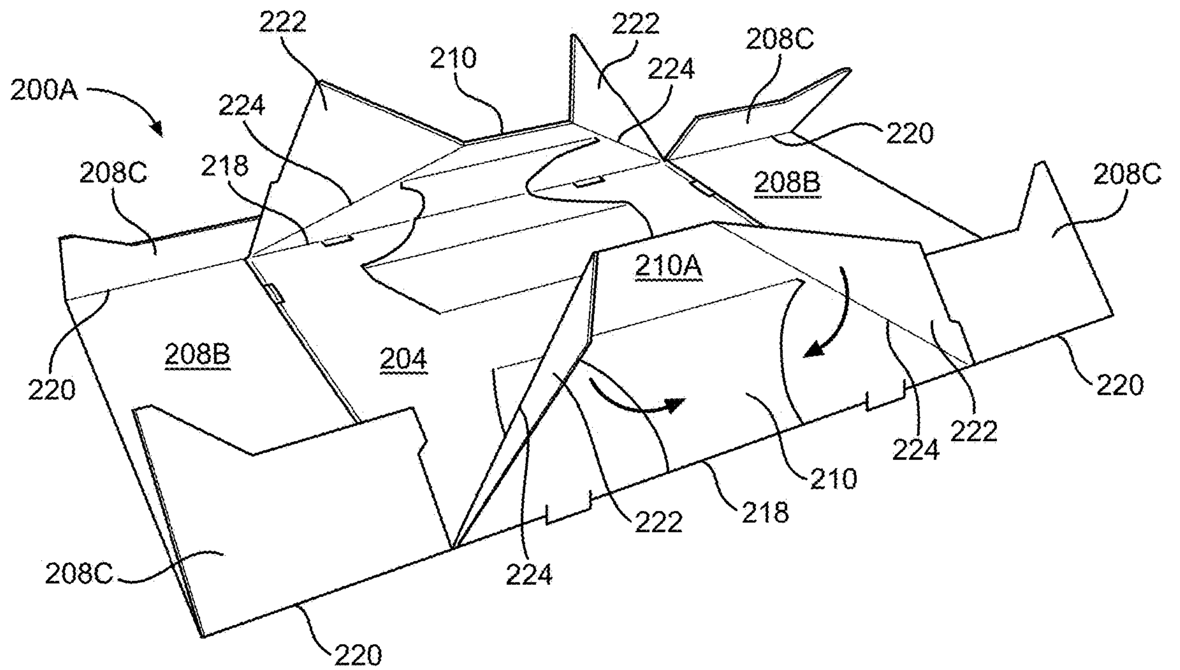
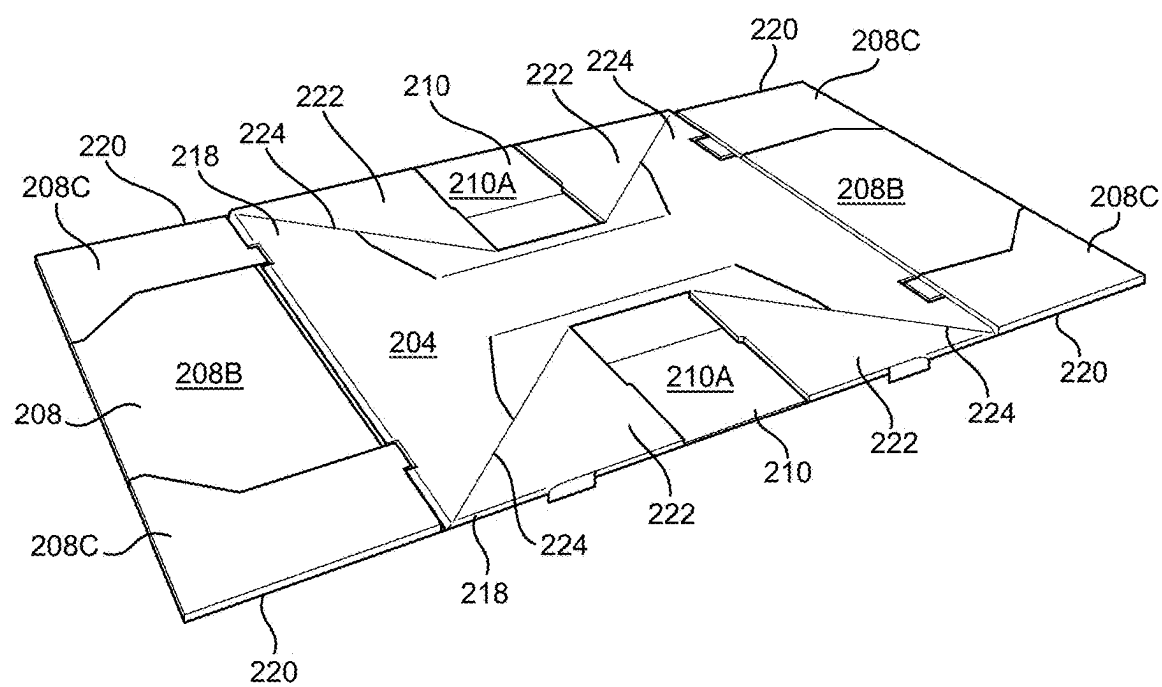

222
222
210
224
208C
200A
224
220
208C
218
208B
208C
210A
220
208B
204
224
222
210
218
222
208C
224
220

FIG. 9


220
208C
222
224
222
210
220
224
208C
218
210A
208B
208C
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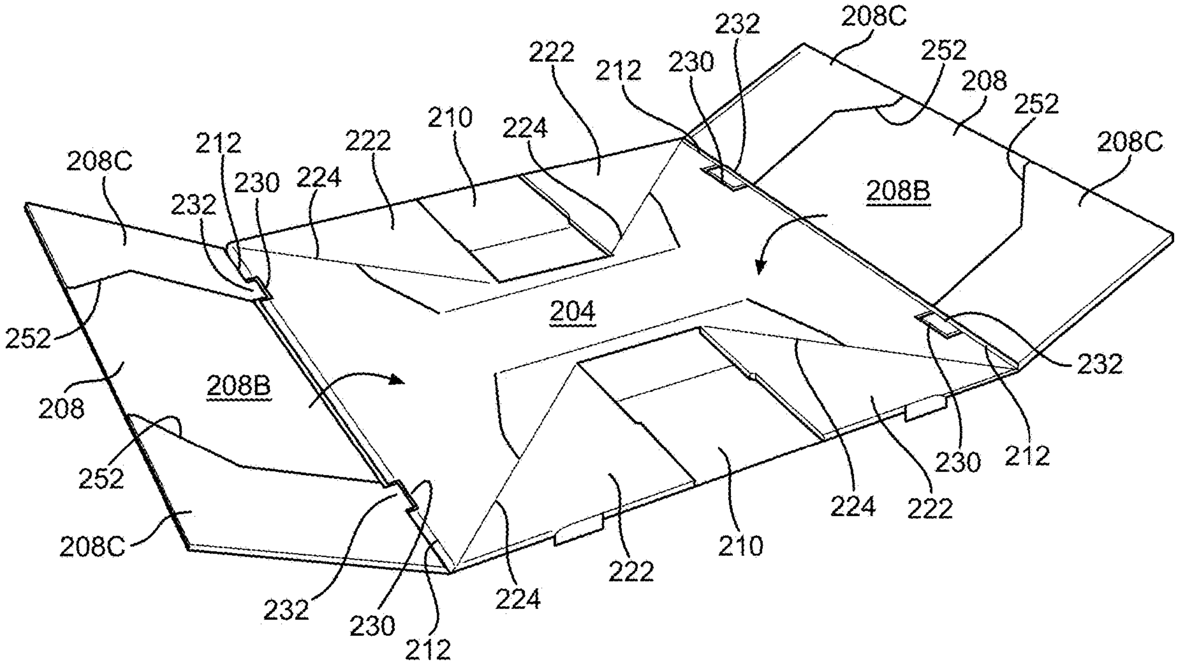
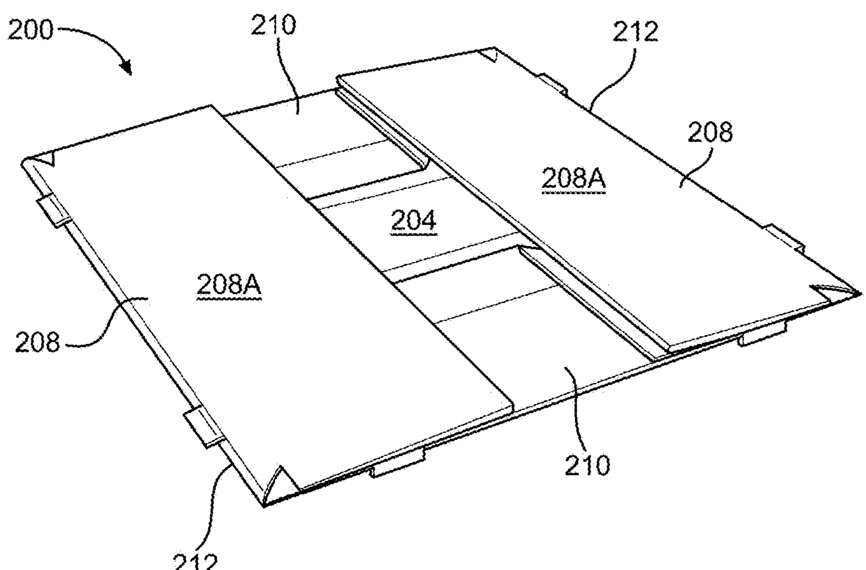
208B
210A
220
208
222
224
210
222
208C
224
218
220

FIG. 10



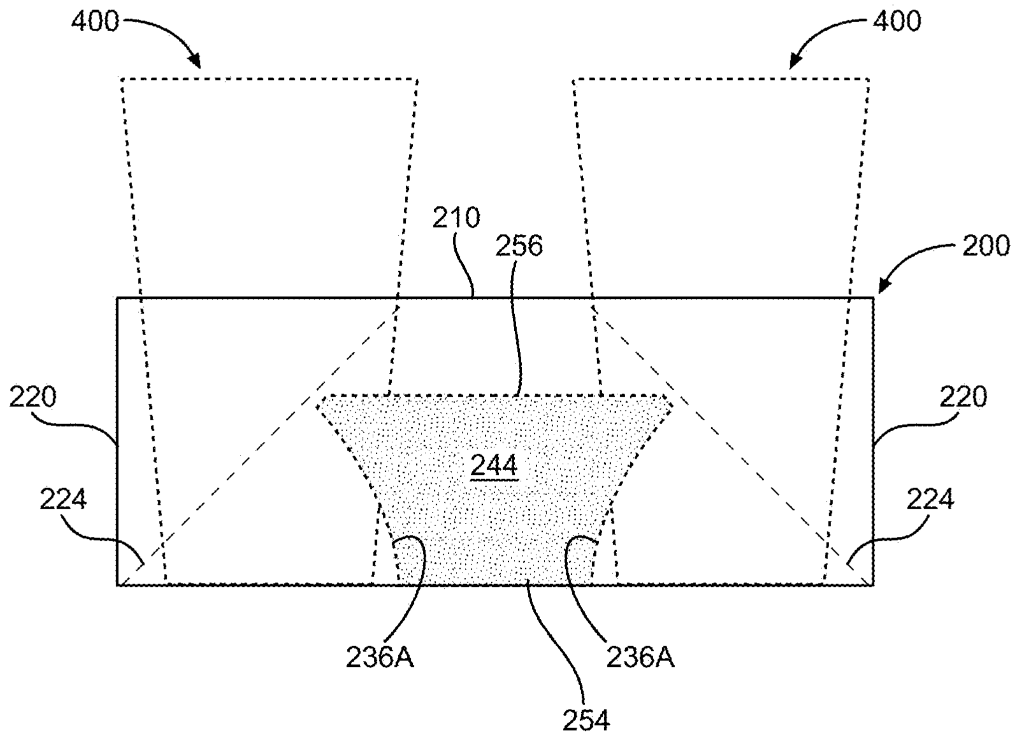
208C
232
230
212
222
210
224
222
212
230
232
208C
252
208
252
208C
208B
204
252
208
208B
252
208C
232
230
212
224
222
210
224
222
230
212
232

FIG. 11



200
210
212
208
208A
204
208A
208
210
212

FIG. 12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400
210
256
200
220
220
244
224
224
236A
236A
254

FIG. 13

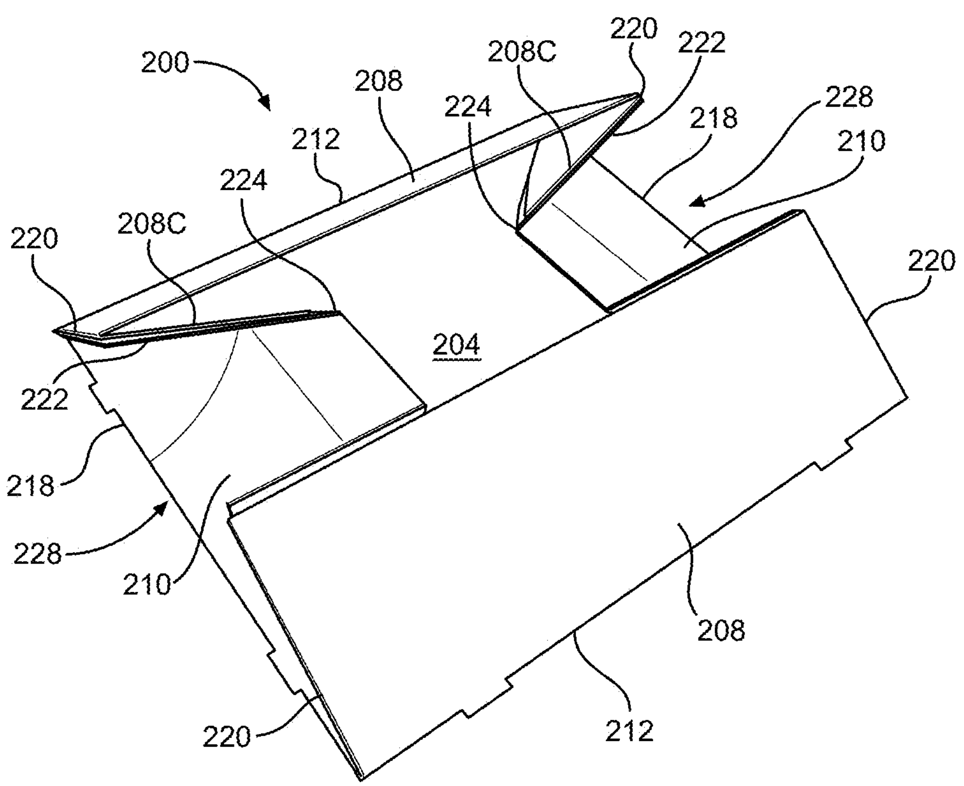
200
208
208C
220
222
228
218
210
212
224
224
220
208C
220
204
222
218
228
210
208
220
212

FIG. 14

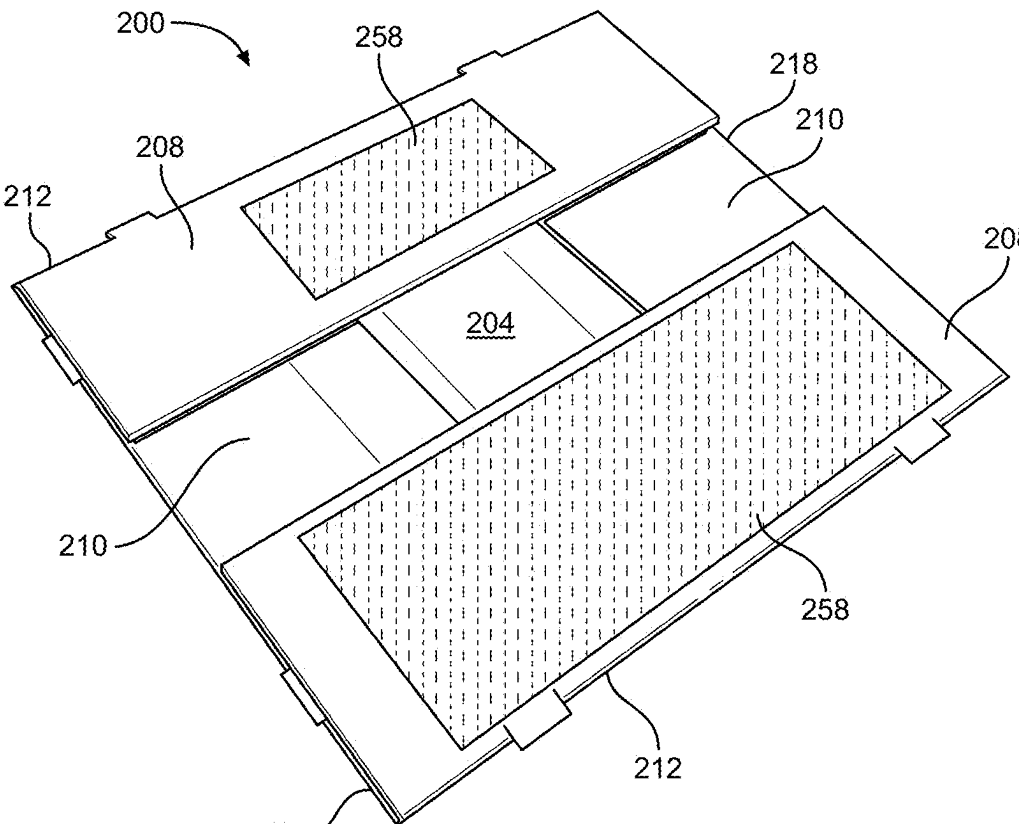

FIG. 15

STADIUM FOOD TRAY AND DRINK CARRIER APPARATUS

CROSS-REFERENCE TO RELATED APPLICATION

[0001] This application claims the benefit of U.S. Provisional Patent Application No. 63/561,553, filed Mar. 5, 2024, which is incorporated by reference herein in its entirety.

FIELD

[0002] This invention relates to containers for food and drink. More particularly, the present invention relates to a food tray and drink carrier container having two-ply reinforced construction and that provides a popout drink holder and integrated carrying handles.

BACKGROUND

[0003] Currently, many sports stadiums, media venues (e.g., theatres, concert halls, etc.), and other event locations that provide concessions serving food and/or drinks utilize molded fiber carriers, such as container **100** shown in FIG. **1**. These containers **100** are provided to customers and are then used by those customers to transport food and drink from one location to another (e.g., from concession stands to customer seats). While useful for this function, containers **100** provide limited utility because they can only be used in a single configuration and provide limited amounts of space. Additionally, containers **100** are not capable of being collapsed and, therefore, often require large amounts of space when being shipped and stored. In an attempt to reduce their overall size to reduce space requirements for shipping and storage, the height of containers **100** may be purposefully limited. This limited height, however, reduces the amount of space available for food and drink, reduces the stability of food and drink carried in the container, and makes carrying food and drink using the container more difficult due to a higher center of gravity.

[0004] What is needed is a stadium food tray and drink carrier container that ships flat and that can convert between a food tray mode, a drink carrier mode, and a food tray and drink carrier mode.

Notes on Construction

[0005] The use of the terms "a", "an", "the" and similar terms in the context of describing the invention are to be construed to cover both the singular and the plural, unless otherwise indicated herein or clearly contradicted by context. The terms "comprising", "having", "including" and "containing" are to be construed as open-ended terms (i.e., meaning "including, but not limited to,") unless otherwise noted. The terms "substantially", "generally" and other words of degree are relative modifiers intended to indicate permissible variation from the characteristic so modified. The use of such terms in describing a physical or functional characteristic of the invention is not intended to limit such characteristic to the absolute value which the term modifies, but rather to provide an approximation of the value of such physical or functional characteristic.

[0006] Terms concerning attachments, coupling and the like, such as "connected" and "interconnected", refer to a relationship wherein structures are secured or attached to one another either directly or indirectly through intervening structures, as well as both moveable and rigid attachments or relationships, unless specified herein or clearly indicated by context. The term "operatively connected" is such an attachment, coupling or connection that allows the pertinent structures to operate as intended by virtue of that relationship.

[0007] The use of any and all examples or exemplary language (e.g., "such as" and "preferably") herein is intended merely to better illuminate the invention and the preferred embodiment thereof, and not to place a limitation on the scope of the invention. Nothing in the specification should be construed as indicating any element as essential to the practice of the invention unless so stated with specificity.

SUMMARY

[0008] The above and other problems are addressed by a unitary blank for use in forming a food tray and drink carrier apparatus configured to be selectively reconfigured between a collapsed configuration and two or more expanded configurations, including a food tray configuration providing a flat space for holding food and a drink carrier configuration providing an upright support in place of the flat space suitable for securing and holding a drink container. The unitary blank includes a bottom panel, a pair of opposing length panels hingedly joined along a bottom edge thereof to the bottom panel, a pair of opposing width panels hingedly joined along a bottom edge thereof to the bottom panel, a support panel hingedly joined and corresponding to opposing ends of each of the length panels, and a folding corner hingedly joined and corresponding to opposing ends of each of the width panels. The length panels are formed by a first length panel portion that is hingedly joined to the bottom panel and a length panel extension portion that is hingedly joined to the first length panel. Each length panel extension portion has dimensions approximating the dimensions of the first length panel portion such that the length panel has a two-ply thickness when the length panel extension portion is folded about the top length joint onto first length panel portion.

[0009] In certain cases, a length of each of the length panel extension portions is reduced by a cutback provided at opposing ends thereof. Each cutback extends continuously from a free end of the length panel extension portion, such that the length of the length panel extension portions is less than a length of the first length panel portion and bottom panel. Preferably, an angled connection portion at each opposing end of the length panel extension portions joins an end of each cutback to opposing ends of the first length panel portions.

[0010] In certain cases, a popout holder is formed as part of the unitary blank and is defined between a pair of spaced apart contoured edges. Preferably, each contoured edge extends continuously along a portion of the bottom panel and along a portion of one of the length panels or along a portion of one of the width panels, wherein one end of the popout holder is hingedly joined to the bottom panel and an opposing end of the popout holder is hingedly joined to the length panel or width panel so that the popout holder can be moved with respect to the unitary blank while remaining attached to the unitary blank between an out position that provides the food tray configuration providing the flat space for holding food and an in position that provides the drink carrier configuration providing the upright support in place of the flat space for holding a drink container.

[0011] Also disclosed is a food tray and drink carrier apparatus. The apparatus includes a carrier that is formed by folding a unitary blank, such as the unitary blank described above, to provide a peripheral wall formed by the pair of opposing length panels, the pair of opposing width panels, the support panels, and the folding corners. A bottom edge of the peripheral wall is foldably joined to the bottom panel. In the collapsed configuration, the peripheral wall is not held upright and is not perpendicular to the bottom panel. On the other hand, in the two or more expanded configurations, the peripheral wall is held upright and perpendicular to the bottom panel to define a food and drinks space that is sized and configured to securely and selectively hold one or more drinks, food, or a combination of one or more drinks and food based on a configuration of the food and drinks space. The apparatus also includes a popout holder that is disposed in and is configured to modify the configuration of the food and drinks space by being selectively moved between a food tray configuration providing a flat space suitable for securing and holding food and a drink carrier configuration providing an upright support in place of the flat space suitable for securing and holding a drink container.

[0012] Finally, also disclosed is a method of forming a food tray and drink carrier apparatus, such as the apparatus described above. In the method, a unitary blank such as the unitary blank provided above is provided. A peripheral wall is formed using the unitary blank by folding the width panels about the bottom edge towards the bottom panel, folding the folding corners towards an outward surface of the width panel, folding the support panels towards the corresponding length panel, folding each length panel and the corresponding support panels about the bottom edge towards the bottom panel, and adhering each of the folding corners to one of the support panels.

BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF THE DRAWINGS

[0013] Further advantages of the invention are apparent by reference to the detailed description when considered in conjunction with the figures, which are not to scale so as to more clearly show the details, wherein like reference numerals represent like elements throughout the several views, and wherein:

[0014] FIG. **1** is a top perspective view of a conventional molded fiber drink carrier;

[0015] FIG. **2** is a top perspective view of a reinforced stadium food tray and drink carrier container according to an embodiment of the present invention;

[0016] FIG. **3** is a plan view depicting an unfolded and unglued one-piece blank used for forming the container shown in FIG. **2**;

[0017] FIG. **4** is a top perspective view depicting the apparatus of FIG. **2** in an expanded full tray configuration having a full food tray section and depicting an optional and removeable insert for a food tray section;

[0018] FIG. **5** is a top perspective view depicting the apparatus of FIG. **2** in an expanded drink carrier configuration, where a pair of popout holders provide four drink corners that are each suited to receive and securely hold a drink container;

[0019] FIG. **6**A is a top perspective view illustrating the apparatus of FIG. **2** in an expanded partial drink carrier and partial food tray configuration, where a single popout holder provides two drink corners that are each suited to receive and securely hold a drink container;

[0020] FIG. **6**B is a plan view illustrating an apparatus according to an alternative embodiment of the present invention that includes a pair of popout holders on each side of the apparatus such that a total of six drinks may be placed into the apparatus;

[0021] FIG. **6**C is a top perspective view of a container according to an embodiment of the present invention where a popout holder includes a plurality of tabs for holding various sized drink containers;

[0022] FIGS. **7-12** illustrate a process for folding the blank shown in FIG. **3** into a container according to an embodiment of the present invention;

[0023] FIG. **13** is a side elevation view showing a width panel of the apparatus of FIGS. **5** and **6**A providing a hand space and integrated carrying handle;

[0024] FIG. **14** is a top perspective view illustrating the apparatus of FIG. **2** in a partially collapsed configuration;

[0025] FIG. **15** is a top perspective view illustrating the apparatus of FIG. **2** in a fully collapsed configuration.

DETAILED DESCRIPTION

[0026] Referring now to the drawings in which like reference characters designate like or corresponding characters throughout the several views, there is shown in FIG. **2** a reinforced paperboard and 100% recyclable stadium food tray and drink carrier container **200** according to an embodiment of the present invention. In FIG. **3**, an unfolded and unglued unitary blank **200**A that may be folded and glued to form the container **200** is shown. Preferably, once the blank **200**A is folded and glued, no further processing is required to form or use container **200**. In use, the container **200** provides a food and drinks space **202** that is sized and configured to securely hold drinks, food, or a combination of drinks and food. Space **202** is defined by a bottom panel **204** that is surrounded by a peripheral wall **206**. The wall **206** is formed by an opposing pair of length panels **208** hingedly joined along a bottom edge thereof to the bottom panel and an opposing pair of width panels **210** that are also hingedly joined along a bottom edge thereof to the bottom panel. Container **200** may be described herein as being or functioning as a "tray," "carrier," etc., which might suggest that the food or drinks carried by such device are in direct contact with the surface of the container. While that may be true in certain cases, it is not true in all cases. In preferred embodiments, container **200** functions as a carrier for food and drink items but is not intended to be used as a bowl or plate that makes direct contact with those food and drink items.

[0027] The bottom panel **204** is formed with single-ply (i.e., one layer) construction. On the other hand, the wall **206** has a two-ply (i.e., two layer) construction along substantially its entire length. In the illustrated embodiment, each of the length panels **208** is formed from a first length panel portion **208**A that is joined to bottom panel **204** along a bottom length joint **212**, and a length panel extension portion **208**B that is joined to first length panel portion (**208**A) along a top length joint **214**. Preferably, joint **212** and joint **214** each extend the entire length L of bottom panel **204** (i.e., in a left-to-right direction, as shown in FIG. **3**). Preferably, as detailed below, length panel extension portion **208**B has dimensions that approximate the dimensions of the first length panel portion **208**A. In particular, in preferred embodiments, the opposing left and right ends of length panel extension portion **208**B (as seen in FIG. **3**) may each be provided with a small cutback **215** such that its overall length is reduced and is slightly less than the length L of bottom panel **204** and first length panel portion **208**A. In each case, the cutbacks **215** extend continuously from a free end **216** located at an end of length panel extension portion **208**B that is opposite top length joint **214**. Then, preferably, an angled connection portion **217** connects an end of the cutbacks **215** of the left and right ends of length panel extension portion **208**B to the left and right ends of the length panel extension portion **208**B where joints **214** and **220** intersect one another. Preferably, bottom panel **204** and first length panel portion **208**A are joined together substantially continuously along their entire length by bottom length joint **212**. Similarly, first length panel portion **208**A and length panel extension portion **208**B are preferably joined together substantially continuously along their entire length along top length joint **214**.

[0028] Next, in the illustrated embodiment, each opposing end of each width panel **210** includes a folding corner **222** that is joined to the rest of the width panel at joint **224**. Each width panel **210** is joined to the bottom panel **204** along a bottom width joint **218** (preferably formed by portions **218**A and **218**B, discussed below). Preferably, joint **218** extends the entire width W of bottom panel **204** (i.e., in a top-to-bottom direction, as shown in FIG. **3**). Length L and width W are approximately equal in the illustrated embodiment but may be different from one another in other embodiments. A support panel **208**C extends laterally outwards from each opposing end of first length panel portion **208**A and each is joined to the first length panel portion (**208**A) along joint **220**. Preferably, first length panel portion **208**A and support panel **208**C are joined together substantially continuously along joint **220**. Support panel **208**C is separated (e.g., by a cut) from the adjacent width panels **210**.

[0029] In the expanded configuration shown in FIG. **2**, wall **206** is securely but removably held perpendicularly to bottom panel **204**. A pair of detents **230** may be located along the joints of intersecting surfaces to assist in holding them at an approximate 90-degree angle to one another. For example, in the illustrated embodiment, two detents **230** are provided along each bottom length joint **212** and along each bottom width joint **218**. In certain embodiments, a support tab **232** is provided on a bottom of support panel **208**C. The support tab **232** may be sized and configured to be received in the detents **230** disposed along bottom width joint **218** when the blank **200**A is folded to form the container **200**.

[0030] Container **200** is also provided with a pair of popout holders **234** that are each designed to be selectively moved between an "in" position (see FIG. **4**) and an "out" position (see FIG. **5**) to convert the container between a food tray configuration, a drink carrier configuration, and a food tray and drink carrier configuration (see FIG. **6**A). In the food tray configuration, the container **200** includes a flat space suitable for holding food. On the other hand, in the drink dray configuration, the container **200** is configured to hold one or more drink containers. Referring again to FIGS. **2** and **3**, each popout holder **234** is formed by and between a pair of profiled edges **236** (preferably formed by portion **236**A and portion **236**B, discussed below) that extend continuously along a portion of the wall **206** and a portion of the bottom panel **204**. Preferably, profiled edges **236** extend either (i) continuously along a portion of the bottom panel **204** and along a portion of both of the length panels **208** or (ii) continuously along a portion of the bottom panel and along a portion of both of the width panels **210**.

[0031] Preferably, one end of the popout holder **234** is hingedly joined to the bottom panel **204** and an opposing end of the popout holder is hingedly joined to the length panel **208** or width panel **210** so that the popout holder can be moved with respect to the unitary blank **200**A while remaining attached to the unitary blank between an out position that provides the food tray configuration providing the flat space for holding food and an in position that provides the drink carrier configuration providing the upright support in place of the flat space for holding a drink container.

[0032] The profiled edges **236**, along with the bottom **204** and peripheral wall **206**, define a "receiver space" **226** that is suitable for holding food (including condiments, etc.) and/or drink of varying sizes. In other cases, such as if two popout holders **234** are placed adjacent one another along the same portion of wall **206**, the receiver space **226** may located between those two popout holders (see FIG. **6**B). In the illustrated embodiments, the profiled edges **236** are identical for each popout holder **234**, but non-identical profiled cuts may be provided in alternative embodiments. Additionally, popout holders **234** are each arranged to provide a provide a receiver space **226** suitable for receiving a drink container (or food items). However, in other embodiments, different profiled cuts may be provided that provide a different type, number, place, or other configurations for food or drink containers or storage.

[0033] In the illustrated embodiment, each profiled edge **236** includes a linear portion (**236**A) and a non-linear portion (**236**B) connected together at ends thereof to form a continuous linear and non-linear contoured cut formed in the unitary blank. Thus, a portion of profiled edges **236** define an opening having a continuous round profile when the popout holder **234** is in the "in" position shown in FIGS. **2** and **6** (as well as one half of the container **200** shown in FIG. **6**A). When a drink container is placed in one of the receiver spaces **226**, the space is formed by the wall **206** and portion **236**A and is sized and configured to receive and to securely hold the drink container. Preferably, each popout holder **234** is formed as a single unitary component. A top surface **238** of the popout holder **234** is cut partially from the width panel **210** and partially from the bottom panel **204**. In particular, the top surface **238** is formed by a wall portion **240** that is cut from one of the width panels **210** of the container **200** and a bottom portion **242** that is cut from the bottom panel **204**. The side surface **238** and top surface **240** of the popout holder **234** are hingedly joined together. Therefore, the popout holder **234** can be moved with respect to the unitary blank **200**A while remaining attached to the unitary blank between (i) an out position that provides the food tray configuration providing the flat space for holding food, where a portion of the top surface and the side surface are parallel with the bottom panel and each form a portion of the flat space and (ii) an in position that provides the drink carrier configuration providing the upright support in place of the flat space for holding a drink container.

[0034] When the blank **200**A is unfolded, the wall portion **240** and the bottom portion **242** are separated by a middle portion **218**A of the bottom width joint **218** that is located between end portions **218**B. Put differently, when the blank **200**A is unfolded, the wall portion **240** is located on one side of the middle portion **218**A and the bottom portion **242** is located on the other side of the middle portion **218**A. In combination, the middle portion **218**A and the end portions **218**B form the continuous bottom joint **218**. The profiled edges **236** also include a second portion **236**B that defines a side surface **244** of the popout holder **234** that is cut entirely from the bottom panel **204**. When the popout holder **234** is in the "in" position shown in FIG. **2**, the top surface **238** of the popout holder is preferably oriented horizontally (i.e., parallel with the bottom panel **204**) while the side surface **244** of the popout holder is preferably oriented vertically (i.e., perpendicular to the bottom panel **204**). Wall portion **240** is joined to width panel **210** at joint **246**, side surface **244** is joined to bottom panel **204** at joint **248**. Top surface **238** is joined to side surface **244** at joint **250**. Additionally, although depicted as being integrated into the width panel **210** and the bottom panel **204**, the popout holders **234** may each be formed entirely separately from the blank **200**A, either separately or as a single unit, and then adhered to the blank at the suitable locations.

[0035] As noted above, the shape of profiled edges **236** is suitable for creating drink corners that are sized and configured to receive a drink container. However, in other embodiments, differently-shaped profiled edges **236** may be used to provide differently types or sizes of receivers, including for receiving food or condiment containers. For example, as shown in FIG. **6**C, in certain embodiments, a plurality of separate and foldable tabs **260** (tab **260**A and tab **260**B are shown) extend away from and are attached to profiled edge **236** at joint **262**, which can be solid or perforated. Tabs **260** are each movable between a contact position that provides a contact surface configured to contact and hold a drink container and a non-contact position where the contact surface does not contact and hold the drink container such that drink containers having outer dimensions (e.g., diameters) of at least two different sizes may be held by the upright support in the drink carrier configuration. Preferably, when the popout holder **234** is in the out or contact position, each tab **260** corresponds to a different sized drink container. For example, first tab **260**A, which extends the furthest away from the profiled edge **236** and holds a smaller drink container than the second tab **260**B or no tab. Thus, tabs **260** may increase the versatility of the container **200**. Preferably, to utilize the different tabs **260**, a user simply places the drink container into the receiver space **226**. The size-appropriate joint **262** will then bend automatically downward and leave the correct sized tab **260** extended. A cut **268** between the tabs **260** allows each tab to move independently of one another. If desired, a user could remove the unnecessary tab **260** by tearing the tab along joint **262**.

[0036] Each of the joints between adjoining sections of blank **200**A, including joints **212**, **214**, **218**, **220**, and **224** may take the form of a crease, complete or partial cut, perforation, or a combination including perforated cuts, cut creases, etc. For example, in the illustrated embodiment, joints **214** and **224** are each cut creases, joints **218** and **220** are formed entirely as perforated cuts. Additionally, in certain cases, end portions of joints **248** and **250** are formed as perforated cuts, while the middle portion between those ends may be a complete cut. As noted above, support panel **208**C is separated from the adjacent width panels **210** by a complete cut. In certain versions, profiled edge **236**, including portion **236**A and portion **236**B, are formed by a complete cut. However, in other embodiments, profiled edge **236** may be formed as a perforation to enable the selective creation of pop-out drink container supports. Lastly, in the illustrated embodiment, joint **212** and middle portion **218**A are both formed using creases (i.e., without any cutting).

[0037] To form a food tray version of container **200** from blank **200**A, the peripheral wall **206** is formed first. With specific reference to FIG. **2** and FIG. **7**, when forming the wall **206**, each of the length panel extension portions **208**B is folded inwards (i.e., towards space **202**, shown in FIG. **2**) along top length joint **214**. Each of the length panel extension portions **208**B is then folded down and adhered (e.g., glued) to first length panel portion **208**A to form the two-ply length panel **208** shown in FIG. **8**. With continued reference to FIG. **8**, width panels **210** are then folded along joint **218** to be oriented perpendicular to bottom panel **204**. Similarly, the support panels **208**C are each folded inwards (i.e., towards space **202**) along joint **220** to be oriented perpendicularly to bottom panel **204** (and parallel with width panel **210**).

[0038] Next, as shown in FIG. **9** and FIG. **10**, each of the folding corners **222** is folded outwards (i.e., away from space **202**, shown in FIG. **2**) along joint **224** and pressed downwards onto an outward facing surface **210**A of width panel **210**. Also, width panel **210** is folded further along joint **218** and is pressed downwards onto bottom panel **204**. At the same time, the support panels **208**C are each folded further inwards (i.e., towards space **202**, shown in FIG. **2**) along joint **220** and are pressed downwards onto an outward facing surface of length panel extension portion **208**B.

[0039] Next, as shown in FIG. **11** and FIG. **12**, length panels **208**, including support panels **208**C, are folded inwards along joint **212**. When length panel **208** is folded upwards in this manner, support tab **232** lands on detent **230** along joint **212**. Detent **230**, and, if present, an extension tab, receives, securely holds and protects support tab **232** from deformation while length panel **208**, including panel portions **208**A, **208**B, and **208**C, is first folded along joint **212** and is then pressed downwards onto bottom panel **204** and folding corners **222** of width panel **210**. During this step of the construction process, each of the support panels **208**C is adhered to one of the folding corners **222**. This completes the construction of the container **200**. When the construction of the container **200** is completed, it is in the collapsed configuration shown in FIG. **12**. Following the procedure described above results in the construction of a full food tray that may be selectively folded out and in between the collapsed configuration shown in FIG. **12** and the expanded configuration shown in FIG. **4**.

[0040] Importantly, almost the entire wall **206** is formed using two-ply construction, including at each of the reinforced receiver spaces **226** that are formed adjacent joint **220**, where length panel **208** intersects width panel **210**. As shown best in FIG. **2**, the wall **206** includes only a pair of small single-ply portions **228**, where support panel **208**C does not overlap with the width panel **210**. Thus, as noted above, the wall **206** has a two-ply (i.e., two layer) construction along substantially its entire length. In three different embodiments, the wall **206** is "substantially" two-ply when more than 50%, more than 75%, and more than 80% of the peripheral wall is formed using two-ply construction.

[0041] In the expanded configuration shown in FIG. **4**, support tab **232** and detents **230** are each engaged and assist in holding length panels **208** and width panels **210** perpendicular to bottom panel **204**. This configuration may be referred to as a "full tray" configuration. In this case, both popout holders **234** are in the "out" position and provide a large flat area in the bottom of the space **202** that can be used for transporting food items. In this position, part of the popout holders **234** form bottom panel **204** and part of the popout holders form part of width panels **210**. In certain instances, to provide further support, an optional and removeable insert **300** may be placed inside of space **202** and on top of bottom panel **204**. The insert **300** may be provided with one or more folds **302** to facilitate its insertion into and removal from the space **202** and to allow the insert to be placed into only one half of the space to allow the popout holder **234** on the other side to still be used.

[0042] A user may easily convert the container **200** such that the space **202** is used partially or entirely as a drink carrier by raising one or more of the popout holders **234**. In FIG. **5**, both popout holders **234** are in the "in" position, and this particular container **200** is capable of carrying up to four drink containers in this configuration. This is a "full carrier" configuration. When the popout holders **234** are in this position, the top surface **238** of each is horizontal (i.e., parallel with bottom panel **204**) and the side surface **244** of each is vertical (i.e., perpendicular to bottom panel). Then, in FIG. **6**, only one of the popout holders **234** is in the in position, and the container **200** is in a "partial tray" configuration or a "partial carrier" configuration that is capable of holding two drink containers **400** and food as well. As shown in FIG. **13**, when either of the popout holders is in the in position, a hand space **254** and integrated carrying handle **256** is provided in that width panel **210**. Thus, by positioning one or both popout holders in the in position, a single carrying handle or a pair of carrying handles may be provided. Advantageously, the presence of handle **256** and the sizing of hand space **254**, places the center of gravity much lower in a customer's hands when using container **200** than when using conventional containers, like container **100** shown in FIG. **1**. A higher center of gravity makes balancing and holding a loaded tray more difficult. Therefore, preferably, the center of gravity is as close to the customer's hands as possible. However, since conventional containers are typically carried from the bottom and drink containers are then placed on top of the convention container, the center of gravity in those cases is typically much higher than the customer's hands.

[0043] Finally, the container **200** can be partially collapsed and then fully collapsed very quickly. The collapsed configuration allows the container **200** to be stored and transported easily and with minimal space required. To collapse container **200**, it is first reconfigured (i.e., partially collapsed) to the "full tray" configuration shown in FIG. **4**, with both popout holders **234** in the out position and the space **202** in the full tray configuration. Next, with reference to FIG. **4**, FIG. **14**, and FIG. **15**, the single-ply portions **228** of the width panels **210** are each folded inwards (i.e., towards the space **202**), while the support panels **208**C are folded along joint **220** and folding corners **222** are folded along joints **224**. Once the support panels **208**C and folding corners **222** are folded in this manner, they both come to rest in a collapsed configuration on top of the width panel.

[0044] It is noted here that, when the support panels **208**C are adhered to the folding corners **222**, angled cut **252** (FIG. **4**) of support panel **208**C is aligned with and is preferably placed directly on or immediately adjacent a portion of joint **224**. This alignment is shown most clearly in FIG. **4**. When the container **200** is transitioned from the expanded configuration shown in FIG. **4** and FIG. **14** to the collapsed configuration shown in FIG. **15**, support panel **208**C is folded along fold line **208**D that is parallel with and co-linear with joint **224** of width panel **210**. In FIG. **4**, only two joints **224** and fold lines **208**D are shown, but an identical pair of each is provided on the opposing width panel **210** and support panels **208**C.

[0045] Now, as shown in FIG. **14** and FIG. **15**, folding width panels **210** along joints **224** in the manner discussed above causes support panel **208**C and folding corner **222**, which are adhered together, to fold rearwards while the single-ply portion **228** folds forwards about joint **218**. This results in width panel **210** resting against bottom panel **204**. Then, a support panel **208**C and folding corner **222** combination rests on top of each end of width panel **210**. Finally, each of the length panels **208** is folded about joint **212** and rests on top of both width panels **210**. Each length panel **208** rests on top of one of the support panel **208**C and folding corner **222** combinations of each of the width panels **210**.

[0046] As illustrated in FIG. **15**, in certain embodiments, space **258** may be provided on an exterior surface of the wall **206** for promotions, etc. In the illustrated embodiment, a separate advertising space **258** is provided on each of the length panels **208**. However, in other embodiments, similar spaces may also be provided on the width panels **210**.

[0047] Although this description contains many specifics, these should not be construed as limiting the scope of the invention but as merely providing illustrations of some of the presently preferred embodiments thereof, as well as the best mode contemplated by the inventor of carrying out the invention. The invention, as described herein, is susceptible to various modifications and adaptations as would be appreciated by those having ordinary skill in the art to which the invention relates.

What is claimed is:

1. A unitary blank for use in forming a food tray and drink carrier apparatus configured to be selectively reconfigured between a collapsed configuration and two or more expanded configurations, including a food tray configuration providing a flat space for holding food and a drink carrier configuration providing an upright support in place of the flat space suitable for securing and holding a drink container, the unitary blank comprising:

- a bottom panel;
- a pair of opposing length panels hingedly joined along a bottom edge thereof to the bottom panel, where each length panel is formed by:
  - a first length panel portion that is hingedly joined to the bottom panel; and
  - a length panel extension portion that is hingedly joined to the first length panel portion at a top length joint, wherein each length panel extension portion that has dimensions approximating the dimensions of the first length panel portion such that the length panel has a two-ply thickness when the length panel extension portion is folded about the top length joint onto first length panel portion;
- a pair of opposing width panels hingedly joined along a bottom edge thereof to the bottom panel;
- a support panel hingedly joined and corresponding to opposing ends of each of the length panels;
- a folding corner hingedly joined and corresponding to opposing ends of each of the width panels.

2. The unitary blank of claim **1** wherein each support panel includes an angled portion extending laterally outwards from the support panel proximate a top edge of the support panel and a support tab disposed along a bottom of the support panel.

3. The unitary blank of claim **2** further comprising a pair of detents located along a joint where the bottom panel intersects with each width panel, each support tab of the length panel being sized and positioned to be inserted into one of said detents when the unitary blank is folded.

4. The unitary blank of claim **1** wherein each of the pair of opposing length panels extends across a substantial entirety of a length of the unitary blank and each of the pair of opposing width panels extends across a substantial entirety of a width of the unitary blank.

5. The unitary blank of claim **1** further comprising a popout holder formed as part of the unitary blank and defined between a pair of spaced apart contoured edges, wherein each contoured edge extends continuously along a portion of the bottom panel and along a portion of one of the length panels or along a portion of one of the width panels, wherein one end of the popout holder is hingedly joined to the bottom panel and an opposing end of the popout holder is hingedly joined to the length panel or width panel so that the popout holder can be moved with respect to the unitary blank while remaining attached to the unitary blank between an out position that provides the food tray configuration providing the flat space for holding food and an in position that provides the drink carrier configuration providing the upright support in place of the flat space for holding a drink container.

6. The unitary blank of claim **5** comprising a popout holder formed on opposing sides of the unitary blank such that each of the contoured edges extend either (i) continuously along a portion of the bottom panel and along a portion of both of the length panels or (ii) continuously along a portion of the bottom panel and along a portion of both of the width panels.

7. The unitary blank of claim **5** wherein the contoured edges of the upright support define a plurality of tabs that are each movable between a contact position that provides a contact surface configured to contact and hold a drink container and a non-contact position where the contact surface does not contact and hold the drink container such that drink containers having outer dimensions of at least two different sizes may be held by the upright support in the drink carrier configuration.

8. The unitary blank of claim **5** wherein each contoured edge includes a linear portion and a non-linear portion connected together at ends thereof to form a continuous linear and non-linear contoured edge formed in the unitary blank.

9. The unitary blank of claim **8** wherein a side surface is formed by the linear portion of the contoured edges and a top surface is formed by the non-linear portion of the contoured edges, wherein the side surface and top surface of the popout holder are hingedly joined together, wherein the popout holder can be moved with respect to the unitary blank while remaining attached to the unitary blank between (i) an out position that provides the food tray configuration providing the flat space for holding food, where a portion of the top surface and the side surface are parallel with the bottom panel and each form a portion of the flat space and (ii) an in position that provides the drink carrier configuration providing the upright support in place of the flat space for holding a drink container, wherein the top surface is parallel with and spaced vertically above the bottom panel and defines a top of the upright support and wherein the side surface is perpendicular to the bottom panel and defines a side of the upright support.

10. The unitary blank of claim **1** wherein a length of each of the length panel extension portions is reduced by a cutback provided at opposing ends thereof, wherein each cutback extends continuously from a free end of the length panel extension portion, such that the length of the length panel extension portions is less than a length of the first length panel portion and bottom panel.

11. The unitary blank of claim **10** wherein an angled connection portion at each opposing end of the length panel extension portions joins an end of each cutback to opposing ends of the first length panel portions.

12. A food tray and drink carrier apparatus comprising:

a carrier formed by folding the unitary blank of claim **1** to provide a peripheral wall formed by the pair of opposing length panels, the pair of opposing width panels, the support panels, and the folding corners, wherein a bottom edge of the peripheral wall is foldably joined to the bottom panel;

wherein, in the collapsed configuration, the peripheral wall is not held upright and is not perpendicular to the bottom panel; and

wherein, in the two or more expanded configurations, the peripheral wall is held upright and perpendicular to the bottom panel to define a food and drinks space that is sized and configured to securely and selectively hold one or more drinks, food, or a combination of one or more drinks and food based on a configuration of the food and drinks space;

a popout holder disposed in and configured to modify the configuration of the food and drinks space by being selectively moved between a food tray configuration providing a flat space suitable for securing and holding food and a drink carrier configuration providing an upright support in place of the flat space suitable for securing and holding a drink container.

13. The apparatus of claim **12** wherein the popout holder is formed by:

a top surface having a wall portion hingedly joined to a bottom portion at a middle portion;

a side surface hinedgely joined to the bottom portion of the top surface; and

a profiled edge located on at least one side of the top surface for at least partially defining a receiver space in the drink carrier configuration,

wherein, when carrier is in the two or more expanded configurations and the popout holder is in the food tray configuration, the wall portion of the top surface is parallel with and co-planar with the peripheral wall and the bottom portion of the top surface and the side surface are both parallel with and co-planar with the bottom panel, and

wherein, when carrier is in the two or more expanded configurations and when the popout holder is in the drink carrier configuration, the wall portion and the bottom portion of the top surface are both parallel with and spaced vertically above the bottom panel and the side surface is parallel with and spaced laterally away from peripheral wall.

14. The apparatus of claim **13** wherein, when the popout holder is in the drink carrier configuration, a hand space and integrated carrying handle is provided by the width panel, and when the popout holder is in the food tray configuration, the popout holder forms part of the peripheral wall.

15. The apparatus of claim **12** further comprising an insert that is sized and configured for removably placement within the container on the bottom panel to provide a two-ply bottom panel.

16. A method of forming a food tray and drink carrier apparatus configured to be selectively reconfigured between a collapsed configuration and two or more expanded configurations, including a food tray configuration providing a flat space for holding food and a drink carrier configuration providing an upright support in place of the flat space for holding a drink container, the method comprising:
- providing a unitary blank comprising:
  - a bottom panel;
  - a pair of opposing length panels, each length panel having a first end, a second end, and hingedly joined along a bottom edge thereof to the bottom panel, where each length panel is formed by:
    - a first length panel portion that is hingedly joined to the bottom panel; and
    - a length panel extension portion that is hingedly joined to the first length panel portion at a top length joint, wherein each length panel extension portion that has dimensions approximating the dimensions of the first length panel portion such that the length panel has a two-ply thickness when the length panel extension portion is folded about the top length joint onto first length panel portion;
  - a pair of opposing width panels hingedly, each width panel having a first end, a second end, and a bottom edge that is hingedly joined to the bottom panel;
  - a support panel hingedly joined and corresponding to opposing ends of each of the length panels;
  - a folding corner hingedly joined and corresponding to opposing ends of each of the width panels,
- providing a popout holder disposed in and configured to modify the configuration of the food and drinks space by being selectively moved between the food tray configuration providing the flat space for holding food and the drink carrier configuration providing the upright support in place of the flat space for holding the drink container;
- forming a peripheral wall with the unitary blank by:
  - folding the width panels about the bottom edge towards the bottom panel;
  - folding the folding corners towards an outward surface of the width panel;
  - folding the support panels towards the corresponding length panel;
  - folding each length panel and the corresponding support panels about the bottom edge towards the bottom panel;
  - adhering each of the folding corners to one of the support panels.

17. The method of claim **16** further comprising reconfiguring the container from the collapsed configuration to a first expanded configuration by raising the peripheral wall into a position perpendicular to the bottom panel.

18. The method of claim **17** wherein the popout holder is formed as part of the unitary blank and is defined between a pair of spaced apart contoured edges, wherein each contoured edge extends continuously along a portion of the bottom panel and along a portion of one of the width panels, wherein one end of the popout holder is hingedly joined to the bottom panel and an opposing end of the popout holder is hingedly joined to the width panel so that the popout holder can be moved with respect to the unitary blank while remaining attached to the unitary blank between an out position that provides the food tray configuration providing the flat space for holding food and an in position that provides the drink carrier configuration providing the upright support in place of the flat space for holding a drink container, the method further comprising reconfiguring the container from the first expanded configuration to a second expanded configuration by moving the popout holder between (i) the food tray configuration, where the upright support is in an out position where a portion of a top surface and a side surface of the upright support are parallel with the bottom panel and each form a portion of the flat space, and (ii) the drink carrier configuration, where the upright support is in an in position where the top surface is parallel with and spaced vertically above the bottom panel and defines a top of the upright support and where the side surface is perpendicular to the bottom panel and defines a side of the upright support.

19. The method of claim **18** wherein the contoured edges define a plurality of tabs that are each movable between a contact position that provides a contact surface configured to contact and hold a drink container and a non-contact position where the contact surface does not contact and hold the drink container such that drink containers having outer dimensions of at least two different sizes may be held by the upright support in the drink carrier configuration, the method comprising moving at least one of the plurality of tabs to reconfigure the upright support from a food tray and drink carrier apparatus suitable for contacting and holding a drink container having a first outer dimension to a food tray and drink carrier apparatus suitable for contacting and holding a drink container having a second and different outer dimension.

20. The method of claim **16**, the unitary blank further comprising a pair of detents located along a joint where the bottom panel intersects with each width panel and a support tab disposed along a bottom of the support panel, the method further comprising, as the length panel and corresponding support panels are folded about the bottom edge towards the bottom panel, inserting one of said support tabs of the length panel into each detent.

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